

Claude Code

What is Claude Code?

Claude Code is an agentic coding tool that understands your codebase, edits your files, runs commands, and integrates with your existing developer tools to help you get things done faster. It's available in your terminal, Visual Studio Code, the Claude Desktop app, on the web, and in JetBrains IDEs.

What Separates Claude Code from Claude?

If you've used Claude.ai before, you might be wondering what makes Claude Code different. Unlike Claude.ai, Claude Code has direct access to your files, your terminal, and your entire codebase. Instead of copying and pasting code back and forth, it goes in and does the work itself.

The key differentiator is that Claude Code works as an **AI Agent**.

What is an Agent?

An AI Agent is software that can interact with its environment and perform actions to complete a defined goal. At its core, this works by having a large language model operating in a loop in real time. AI

Agents can have access to tools, external services, or even other AI Agents to help reach their goals.

What Can Claude Code Actually Do?

Here's what that looks like in practice:

- **Read and understand your codebase.** You can ask Claude Code to explain a feature or trace a bug throughout your code.
- **Edit files across your project.** Claude Code can refactor a function and update every file that references it.
- **Run terminal commands.** It can execute your build script, run your tests, install packages, and use the output to decide what to do next.
- **Search the web.** If it needs documentation or the latest API references, it can look that up for you.

Using Claude Code Effectively

To use Claude Code effectively, keep these three concepts in mind:

The context window. Think of this as Claude's working memory. It can hold a lot, but not everything at once. This is where the "agentic" aspect comes in — Claude finds strategic ways to locate answers within your codebase without loading the entire thing into context.

It asks for permission. By default, Claude Code will ask you before running commands or making changes. You're always in control, whether you prefer a hands-on or hands-off approach.

It can make mistakes. Just like any tool, Claude Code isn't perfect. It might misunderstand your intent, introduce a bug, or over-engineer a solution. Staying in the loop helps you catch these early.

Recap

Claude Code is an agentic coding tool. It reads your codebase, edits your files, runs commands, and connects to external tools to help you ship faster. You can use it today in your terminal, VS Code, JetBrains, and the Claude Desktop app.

How Claude Code Works

Claude Code is different from typical chat applications. Understanding how it works under the hood will help you use it more effectively.

The Agentic Loop

Claude Code is best explained through the **agentic loop**:

1. You enter a prompt into Claude Code.
2. Claude gathers the context it needs by interacting with the model, which returns text or a tool call that Claude Code can execute.
3. It takes action — for example, editing a file or running a command.
4. It verifies the results and determines whether they achieve what your prompt set out to do.
5. If they do, Claude finishes and waits for the next prompt. If they don't, it loops back and tries again until the results are complete and verifiable.

Throughout this loop, you can add context, interrupt, or steer the